

Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System (WHMIS)

WHMIS: Education and Training Requirements

Let's get right into common questions you may have if your workplace is required to provide WHMIS, or Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System, education and training. You need to understand what you should know to be adequately protected at work.

Education and training can be thought of as two separate parts. Education refers to the instruction of workers in general information such as how WHMIS works and the hazards of controlled products. Training refers to the instruction in site-specific information such as work and emergency procedures. Both education and training are essential in understanding the hazards you may encounter in your workplace.

All Canadian jurisdictions require that employers develop, implement, and maintain a worker education program that will enable workers to work safely with hazardous chemicals. Instruction on requirements for labels and data sheets, information on how products may affect the worker's health or safety, as well as training in safe work procedures are necessary. The employer has a general responsibility to provide all available hazard information, whether it comes from suppliers, or it's information the employer is, or ought to be, aware of. This duty is largely accomplished through education and training programs offered on a regular basis.

The specific WHMIS education and training requirements are regulated by each occupational health and safety jurisdiction. If you work in a federal workplace, you should contact the Labour Branch of Human Resources Development Canada to determine the exact nature of the WHMIS requirements applicable to you. If you don't work in a federal workplace, contact the regulating body in your provincial and territorial jurisdictions. This outline is intended for general information purposes only.

The purpose of WHMIS training is to provide workers with knowledge and information that they can understand and apply to protect their health and safety on a daily basis. The specific details that must be included in training will vary from one workplace to another.

For example: it's not enough for a worker to know that the Material Safety Data Sheet, or MSDS, suggests a particular type of respirator for protection against a certain product. The worker must also be trained on where to get the respirator, locations in the plant where its use is mandatory, how to test it for fit, and how to maintain and store it.

A training program is successful when employees know and use safe procedures with controlled products and understand why safe procedures are necessary.

Another example that proves a worker is adequately trained is if they know the best way to respond to an emergency. What if a dangerous chemical splashes in a worker's eye? Do they know where the safety showers are located, how to alert others to a splash or a spill in the area, and other emergency procedures?

Workplace-specific training needs to address the best emergency responses for the physical worksite, with its specific layout, hazards, and the type of work performed.

A WHMIS training program generally has two parts.

One part is about labels, MSDSs, and other identifiers. This part of training includes the content of the label and MSDS, as well as the purpose, significance—why a product is called a corrosive, for example—location, and modes of identification such as colours, numbers, and abbreviations.

The second part of training is related to work procedures such as storage, handling, use, disposal, emergencies, and what to do in unusual situations, such as when fugitive emissions occur.

Now, it's important that people receive training relevant to the safety of their own jobs. Just because people work in the same plant, doesn't mean they should receive the same training. Instruction should be based on the information on labels and safety data sheets, as well as the specific

workplace conditions. For example, anhydrous ammonia might be a hazard in your workplace. If so, workers need to know how to specifically protect themselves while working around a pressurized gas.

Basically, the level of training will depend on the nature of the work. Another example is a maintenance person who needs instruction on working with chemicals, various processes, and much more. Office workers in the same facility will likely only need training on emergency procedures. ///

You can measure how successful a training program is by having workers answer these four questions:

One...Where can I get hazard information?

Everyone in the workplace should be aware of how to get the information provided by the labels and MSDSs, how to identify products, and what the labels mean. If safety data sheets are kept in a physical location, such as a binder, everyone should know exactly where to find it. In cases where the information is digital, everyone should have access to a computer with the digital information.

Two... What are the hazards of a controlled product?

By reading the label, the worker should be able understand the specific dangers or harmful effects that a certain product may have on their health and safety.

Three... How am I protected from hazards?

Workers need to understand how their workplace is protecting their safety from the risks that the onsite hazardous substances present. There are all kinds of ways... protection through engineering controls, such as protective barriers; administration, such as by teaching safe work practices; or by using personal protective equipment.

Finally, four... What should I do in case of an emergency?

It's critical that every worker understands the correct procedures to follow in the event of a spill, release, fire, or poisoning involving a controlled product. If there is personal protective equipment that can be used in an emergency, such as a respirator, everyone should know where it is and how to effectively wear it.

So, now that we've covered how workplaces with hazardous products are required to train and educate their employees, consider your own workplace. Do you feel prepared to protect your own health and wellbeing? Are you informed enough? Where can you seek out more information? Take charge of your own wellness and make sure you're always making safety a priority.